

VoIP and Traditional Telecom: 1 Minus 1 or 1 Plus 1?

With existing circuit-switched networks still in good shape, will telephony service providers ever venture to replace them with IP-based networks? Not likely. But VoIP definitely has its bundle of benefits, and can perhaps be used in areas where legacy infrastructure does not exist, or to enhance existing telecom services using facilities like SIP trunking



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Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) has been talked about a lot—bouquets or brickbats, it has had its share. From policy misunderstandings to implementation hitches, there have been and continue to be many thorns in its path. However, the truth remains that it is a winning concept that will endure the test of time.

"The benefits of IP technology will always outweigh that of the old circuit-switched technology. The circuit-switched networks will eventually be phased out. It is simply a matter of how many years before the migration takes place," comments Ashish Sharma, vice president-marketing, Alvarion.

The VoIP advantage

"Technology-wise VoIP is better, cheaper, dynamic, less resource-intensive and more feature-rich. Organisational users can greatly benefit from end-to-end connectivity, while the initial investment in equipment and setup is also comparatively less in the case of VoIP. There is also a huge gap between the two when it comes to sound quality," says Srinivasan S., founder and director of VIVA Communications.

Simply put, the fact that VoIP can work over existing broadband networks makes it a low-cost option, while the versatile nature of the Internet protocol makes VoIP a multi-faceted and unified communications tool.

VoIP means more than just high-

definition digital voice communication. It also brings with it a bundle of other features such as convergence with other IP-based communications, scalability, low maintenance in the long run, voice mail on email, three-way conferencing, speed dialling, call forwarding, simultaneous ring, call waiting, caller ID, call return, caller ID block, anonymous call rejection, 'do not disturb' feature, last number redial and more.

It is also quite easy to install and use these days, whether for a corporate or for an individual. "A PC, broadband connection and an analogue telephone adaptor (ATA), which the VoIP service provider will offer to the customer as part of the deal, is what one needs to start using VoIP. There is no costly infrastructure and with the ATA in place, one can use his/her normal telephone to make VoIP calls," explains Srinivasan.

One of the biggest benefits of VoIP is probably the portability that it offers. Since an IP address is what identifies each IP phone, the user can be reached at the same number regardless of where he plugs the phone in. While normal telephones are permanently linked to the telephone lines, the ATA can be taken anywhere, and by simply attaching it to a normal telephone and an Internet connection, one can make VoIP calls, without the roaming charges as in the case of mobile phones. This makes the system portable, flexible and cost-effective.

In the long term, the scalability of VoIP networks also proves to be a